

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Flash flood

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Move to higher ground immediately if a flash-flood warning affects you or water is rising. Never cross flowing water on foot or in a vehicle. Leave low areas, canyons and basements without waiting to see how high the water gets.

Do now.

**Get uphill**

01

Move away from streams, low roads and drainage channels.

**Turn around**

02

Do not drive across a flooded road; the roadbed may be missing.

**If trapped**

03

Call emergency services and move to a higher open level without becoming trapped in a closed attic.

**Follow routes**

04

Use current evacuation and road-closure instructions.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Move uphill before the route fills; leave belongings behind. If trapped above floodwater, remain in a safe elevated position and signal your location. Do not attempt to swim a current or enter water to rescue property.

Watch for.

A small-looking current can sweep away people and vehicles.

People & practical needs.

Plan a route that avoids low crossings and can be used by everyone. Carry children only within the helper's real ability and do not attempt improvised water rescues. Know where the family will regroup on higher ground.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Wait for official clearance. Water may rise after rain stops or when storms occur upstream.

Check the next usable option

Wait for official clearance. Water may rise after rain stops or when storms occur upstream.

When the first option is unavailable

Move uphill before the route fills; leave belongings behind. If trapped above floodwater, remain in a safe elevated position and signal your location. Do not attempt to swim a current or enter water to rescue property.

Questions in the field.

Can I cross a shallow-looking road?

Do not enter moving or uncertain floodwater on foot or in a vehicle. Depth, current and road damage are difficult to assess from the surface. Choose another route or a safer higher location before the crossing becomes your only option.

A warning arrives while camping - now what?

Move out of low channels and drainage paths promptly when safe. Conditions upstream can change your location quickly even without local rain. Keep the group together and carry only essentials that do not delay the move.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Flash flood · official guidance

<https://www.weather.gov/safety/flood>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/flash-flood/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.